
Chapter 2 — Group 2

CODEPENDENCE IS A LACK OF TRUST

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your next group. Answer the questions in the chapter before coming to group. In group, you will simply share what your answers were and participate in a brief discussion held by the group facilitator. As with the prior chapter, if both you and your partner are attending the same group, each of you should separately answer the questions in your own book.]

Why do people change their behavior and “give up” some of their important beliefs, wants, and desires in relationships? Of course, in important relationships it is necessary to make *some* compromises. You will have to share a bathroom, a refrigerator, TV, and make some adjustments in your home life. But when people constantly “self-sacrifice” something that is *really* important to them, don’t you think that they would begin to feel a little bad about themselves?

The answer to the question posed above (why do we sacrifice important things?) isn’t always simple. Nor is it always the same answer. But there is usually one commonality in all of them. One underlying reason is usually present — **the person who sacrifices doesn’t trust.**

People also sacrifice because they believe that it will give them a **sense of power in the relationship.** This is strange, because when a sacrifice like this is made, it **gives others power.** Think about the example from Chapter 1. The young woman who let the man smoke in her presence was giving the man permission — power — to smoke everywhere he wanted. But she probably did it because she believed that she wouldn’t offend him and he’d be more likely to stay with her. She believed that by letting him smoke that she’d keep the relationship. It was a decision she made because *she believed it gave her some power and control* in the relationship. Yet, it gave the man power over her.

Now, what does this have to do with trust? Well, put simply, the young woman **doesn’t trust herself or him.** If she is true to herself (and tells him she would rather he not smoke), she believes she might lose him. So by going against her own desires and beliefs, she believes that it gives her some advantage — some power over the situation. She lacks trust in her own basic beliefs and desires about how she wants to be treated. She also lacks trust in him. She believes that if she tells him the truth, he might leave her. So she believes that she can’t be honest with him. **Whenever we feel like we can’t tell the truth, we lack trust.**

The smoking situation we have been describing might not be all that important to some people. But there are times that people sacrifice really important things. We’ve watched as elderly parents put their home up to make bond for a son who was arrested for some crime. After their son was released on bond, he left — he ran. He was eventually caught and brought back for trial, but the threatening bond company caused a great deal of worry in the parents. They almost lost their home.

We’ve seen lots of cases where wives gave up food and clothing for their children so the husband could continue to do his drugs. We’ve watched women work in jobs 12 hours a day and spend the rest of their 12 hours taking care of the children and the house so that the man could drink and “pretend” he couldn’t find a job.

We’ve seen people give up (sacrifice) school, careers, money, cars, time, jobs, sex, and friends to keep a negative relationship. We’ve seen people give into sex to keep a relationship. People can and do betray their most cherished beliefs and values to stay in negative relationships. They believe that if they stay true to themselves, they’ll lose their relationship.

One major objective of this chapter is to have you begin to look at your own level of trust with yourself and your partner. Do you trust yourself? Do you trust your partner? Can you honestly answer the questions that follow?

I. What Important Things Have You Sacrificed?

Chances are that you have sacrificed some important things because of your relationships. You have probably "given up" (or compromised) on some goals, activities, and beliefs. In the last chapter, you began looking at some of these. This chapter takes it a little further.

1. List at least two (2) *favorite* activities you have given up because of your current relationship. (Examples could be movies, spending time with family/friends, reading, money, sports, bowling, church.)

1. I stopped hanging out with friends.
2. I stopped going out altogether on my own.
3.

2. When did you give these activities up?

1. I gave these up very early within the first couple months.
2.
3.

3. What did you *lose* when you gave them up? (Examples: I lost freedom, friends, a sense of accomplishment, relaxation, serenity.)

1. I lost my friends. I wasn't able to make new friends after we moved.
2. I didn't have any peace in my life.
3. I lost hope and fell back into depression.

4. List an important long-term goal that you have "given up" or temporarily sacrificed because of your relationship. (Example: I wanted a college degree.)

My goal: Weight loss/healthier lifestyle

5. What did you lose when you "gave up" that goal?

I lost: A lot of self-esteem and self-respect. I didn't have hope to change.

6. What are at least two important beliefs you compromised or "sacrificed" because of your relationship? (Examples: I believed that it was wrong to drink in front of children; I believed that it was wrong to steal; I believed that I was a good person.)

1. I would constantly say I was a "bad person. At some point I began to believe it and did for several years after the relationship.
2. I learned helplessness. I could never get things right, so I stopped trying to do anything.
3.

7. When did you give these beliefs up?

1. There was no single time. Especially at the end when I realized I was abusive, I had a lot of trouble finding the good in myself, but it had already been instilled that I wasn't a good person by then. I think
2. almost all of it came about the midpoint of our relationship 2nd year when I gave up hope of anything getting better.
3.

8. What did you lose when you gave them up? (Examples: I lost self-esteem; I lost self-trust; I lost faith; I lost respect.)

1. All of the examples. I was pretty deep into depression by the end of the relationship. I had no belief in myself; I didn't think I was a good person. I didn't think I could do anything and
2. felt completely lost and helpless. And when I did anything, it wasn't good, it was never enough and never would be.
3. _____

II. The True Self & False Self — Questions

Remember that *codependence is a pattern of negative behaviors that develop because of involvement with someone*. These behaviors are wide-ranging. They can go from one extreme to the other. Constant arguments can be a form of codependence. Giving the “silent treatment” is also codependence. People who get into such relationships are usually unhappy and think, “I’m not acting like myself. I don’t like being this way.”

For a moment, recall the example of the woman who let the man smoke around her. Let’s say that up to the relationship with that man she *always* avoided smokers and smoking areas. She knew that smoke was unhealthy, she didn’t like the way it made her clothes smell, and she had a commitment to herself about standing up for herself.

When she first told the man she was dating that she “didn’t mind” him smoking in the car, was she being true to herself? The answer is simple — no, she wasn’t being true to her own beliefs and commitments. As time passed, and she allowed him to smoke again and again, she became less and less true to herself. Another part of her developed — that part is sometimes called the *false-self*.

The *false-self* develops over time as we do things that we don’t really want to do and usually believe to be wrong. For example, most people believe that they should be on time for their job. But, of course, most people are occasionally late for work. Sometimes, people will lie about why they are late — they make lame excuses — despite the fact they believe that they should be on time. So over time they begin to develop ways of thinking and acting that permit them to violate their own beliefs.

When you are doing things that go against your basic ideals and beliefs, you are usually following your *false-self*. For example, most addicts don’t want to be addicts. Yet, they aren’t following the desires of their *true-self* when they do drugs. They are following the *false-self*. Most alcoholics don’t want to be alcoholics. They wish their drinking could be stopped or controlled. A part of themselves tells them repeatedly that they should stop or at least cut back on alcohol. That part is the *true-self*. We have often referred to the *true-self* as the **Inner Self**.

Your **Inner Self**, your *true-self*, has given you hints about what you need to be happy in life. It steers you into careers and hobbies that serve your abilities and talents. It tries to guide you through situations by telling you the right thing to do. Yet, our relationships can seem to stop us from following that path. People give up on careers and school because of codependent relationships. Some people are miserable for their whole lives because of it.

1. List three of your behaviors that *come from your false-self*. (Examples: I have permitted drinking in front of the children; I drank at work; I quit school; I made excuses about things; I made excuses about my partner’s behavior; I avoided talking about something important; I lied to my parents; I avoided my friends; I quit a job; I avoided confronting a person.)

1. I said she was always right. And believed it. I could do no right and she could do no wrong.
2. I lied a lot. Like fascist government levels of a lot. I would have drawn weather on a map and sworn that was the actual weather.
3. I tried to hide from everything and isolate. I just wanted to be alone.

2. Why are the behaviors you listed in the prior section part of your false-self? (Examples: I really know it's wrong to drink in front of the kids, but I allowed it anyway; I knew that I shouldn't drink at work; I really wanted that career, and I really liked school, but I quit anyway.)

1. I believe in compromise and working together. That we need mutuality to get by in the world with other humans.
2. I don't like lying. I think that it makes things worse and am deliberate about telling the truth even when it's going to not be a straight forward process.
3. I'm not that outgoing, but I like to do things. I do them on my own, but I like to do them, whatever they are.

3. Take a few moments and think about your *true-self*, your Inner Self for a few moments. It contains your abilities — your aspirations to be the best you can be. List at least three things that *you do really well and that you also enjoy* doing. These should not be negative. (Examples: I'm good at drawing and I enjoy it; I'm a good singer, and I enjoy it.)

1. I am good at my work. I am transparent, I do work that people like and I am working up.
2. I can do "dad jokes".
3. I am good at baking, and I enjoy it. I need an ingredient list, but I usually don't need instructions.

4. In discussing the Inner Self, we have written that people often say that, "Sometimes I feel like two people. I want to do what is right and I want to be successful and happy. But something just 'takes over' and I'm back to doing what I did before."

The "two people" feeling is the conflict between the **true-** and **false-self**. One reason why people follow the false-self is fear. That is, they fear what will happen if they change. List three things you fear might happen if you follow your true-self. (Examples: I might lose my relationship; People might make fun of me; I'd have to move.)

1. I don't feel that kind of duality in my life. I don't worry about following my true-self at all.
2. Something happened in my life and I decided to not worry about that anymore. I need to do what will make me happy. I need to be true to myself and go after what I can.
3. _____

5. Deciding to quit allowing the false-self to have power over us *requires trust in the Inner Self* and faith. Can you begin to trust your Inner Self? Write below what trusting your Inner Self means to you. In group, you will read what you wrote and answer a few questions about it.

Trusting my inner self can allow me to grow. I can accept impermanence and change much better. When something is painful, I don't also

have to introduce suffering. Without suffering, I can stay away from the cycles and loops that lead me to think that things must be better and act out in our underlying tendencies toward such as through anger or selfishness.

If you have filled out this chapter before group and shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.